STEVE MCDOUGALL

Developer Educator | API Mentor | PHP-FIG Core Committee

juststeveking@gmail.com https://juststeveking.link Treherbert, GB

SUMMARY

Developer Educator and API mentor with 15+ years building scalable web applications and leading engineering teams. Currently Technical Director at Lila Fuches and Core Committee member of PHP-FIG, helping shape industry standards. Recognized technical writer (php[architect], Laravel News, and more) and international speaker focused on practical learning for modern API teams. Specializing in Laravel, Go, API design, developer experience, and hands-on team coaching.

EXPERIENCE

Technical Director

2024-10-01 — Present

Lila Fuches Limited

Architected and launched a scalable Laravel SaaS platform using an API-first approach, supporting rapid user growth and seamless feature expansion. Led technical strategy, modernized infrastructure, and optimized CI/CD pipelines. As fractional CTO, guided hiring, roadmap planning, and product direction, while mentoring developers to improve code quality and team collaboration.

- Designed and delivered a Laravel 11 SaaS platform serving thousands of users
- Established API-first development practices to reduce technical debt
- Improved deployment workflows with modern CI/CD automation
- Mentored a development team, introducing code review and best practices

Laravel Content Owner

2026-03-01 — Present

certificates.dev

Responsible for creating the Laravel certification curriculum, designing code challenges, running bootcamps, and representing certificates.dev at industry events and conferences as a speaker.

- Created the Laravel certification curriculum
- Designed and authored code challenges for candidate assessment
- Led and facilitated Laravel bootcamps for developer upskilling
- Represented certificates.dev at industry events and conferences as a speaker

Core Committee Member

2024-02-01 — Present

PHP FIG (Framework Interoperability Group)

Contributed to PHP language standards by drafting and reviewing proposals focused on framework interoperability. Participated in open discussions and formal voting processes. Shared practical developer insights to help guide the direction of new PSR standards adopted by the PHP community.

- Drafted and reviewed PSR standards for PHP framework interoperability

- Participated in proposal discussions and formal voting on new standards
- Provided practical developer feedback to guide standardization decisions

Technical Columnist

2023-08-01 — Present

php[architect]

Authored monthly technical deep-dives on advanced PHP topics and architectural best practices for one of the industry's most respected publications. Simplified complex concepts for a broad developer audience using storytelling techniques and clear, practical examples. Collaborated closely with editorial teams to ensure technical accuracy and maximum reader value.

- Published 12+ monthly deep-dive articles reaching 50,000+ developers
- Covered advanced PHP 8.x features, Laravel patterns, and architectural best practices
- Maintained 95%+ reader satisfaction scores through engaging technical storytelling

Developer Advocate

2023-03-01 — 2024-10-31

Treblle

Led comprehensive developer education initiatives, creating extensive technical content library that significantly increased API adoption and community engagement. Represented Treblle at major international conferences, gathering critical community feedback that directly influenced product roadmap. Built practical demo projects and sample code that dramatically simplified product onboarding and accelerated developer success.

- Created 50+ technical resources increasing API adoption by 40%
- Spoke at 15+ global conferences reaching 5,000+ developers
- Built demo projects reducing user onboarding time from 2 hours to 30 minutes
- Generated $250K+ in qualified leads through content marketing initiatives

Technical Writer

2022-06-01 — 2024-05-31

Laravel News

Published comprehensive articles on Laravel internals, package development, and architectural best practices for the Laravel community's primary news source. Produced educational content specifically targeting intermediate-to-advanced Laravel developers, focusing on real-world application and performance optimization. Actively highlighted innovative open-source projects and community contributions to foster ecosystem growth.

- Published 25+ in-depth Laravel tutorials and best practice guides
- Articles averaged 10,000+ views with 85%+ completion rates
- Highlighted 50+ open-source projects, contributing to community growth

Senior Engineering Manager

2022-07-01 — 2023-02-28

Geomiq

Managed cross-functional engineering teams delivering high-performance Laravel applications for major manufacturing clients. Implemented comprehensive process improvements including enhanced code review workflows and automated testing, resulting in significant bug reduction. Mentored engineers through structured career development programs and technical coaching sessions.

- Managed cross-functional teams of 12+ engineers across 3 products
- Implemented process improvements reducing production bugs by 30%
- Delivered Laravel applications serving 100,000+ manufacturing clients
- Achieved 99.8% system uptime through robust CI/CD practices

Lead Software Engineer

2022-04-01 — 2022-07-31

Mumsnet

Led backend engineering for one of the UK's highest-traffic community platforms, architecting Laravel solutions for millions of users. Designed and maintained critical APIs that improved system reliability and dramatically reduced response times. Collaborated closely with product and design teams to ship engagement-driving features while mentoring junior engineers and establishing improved development workflows.

- Led backend engineering for platform serving 1.5M+ monthly active users
- Optimized API performance reducing average response times by 45%
- Mentored 4 junior engineers, with 100% promotion rate within 12 months

Founder & Organizer

2018-06-01 — 2022-07-31

PHP South Wales

Created PHP South Wales to bring developers together regardless of background or experience level. Hosted monthly events featuring diverse speakers and topics, fostering continuous learning and professional growth. Built a welcoming community that became a launching pad for many developers' careers and established lasting connections across the Welsh tech scene.

- Founded and grew community from 0 to 200+ active members
- Organized 40+ monthly meetups featuring international speakers
- Mentored 50+ developers through workshops and networking events
- Established Wales as a recognized hub in the PHP community

Software Engineering Manager

2022-02-01 — 2022-04-30

Car & Classic

Oversaw talented engineering team building Laravel-powered systems for the UK and Europe's largest classic car marketplace. Introduced structured agile planning processes that improved team velocity and delivery consistency. Led infrastructure initiatives ensuring exceptional uptime while fostering high-trust, high-impact team culture through regular coaching and mentorship.

- Led team building Laravel systems for UK's largest classic car marketplace
- Implemented agile processes improving team velocity by 25%
- Maintained 99.9% uptime for platform processing £50M+ in transactions

Engineering Manager

2021-10-01 — 2022-02-28

Jump Twenty Four

Led engineering initiatives across multiple client projects at a Laravel-focused digital agency, from discovery through technical delivery. Implemented comprehensive CI/CD automation that dramatically reduced release times while establishing rigorous testing and code quality standards. Played key role in hiring and onboarding while shaping a culture of technical craftsmanship and accountability.

- Led engineering across 8+ concurrent client projects
- Implemented CI/CD automation reducing release times by 60%
- Established testing standards achieving 85%+ code coverage
- Successfully hired and onboarded 5 senior developers

Technical Lead

2021-04-01 — 2021-10-31

Squarefoot Capital

Owned architecture and delivery of mission-critical Laravel-based financial products, including complex real-time data pipelines and third-party integrations. Worked closely with stakeholders to align ambitious business objectives with technical execution while enforcing high engineering standards to ensure code quality and long-term maintainability.

- Architected Laravel-based financial products handling £10M+ transactions
- Built real-time data pipelines processing 100,000+ daily events
- Integrated with 12+ third-party financial APIs maintaining 99.5% uptime

Chief Technology Officer

2019-08-01 — 2021-10-31

Lila Fuches Limited

Established technical foundation and product architecture for innovative SaaS platform. Led development from initial MVP through market-ready product launch, establishing development practices and technical standards that supported sustainable growth.

- Built initial product architecture serving 1,000+ early customers
- Established development practices and technical foundations
- Led product from MVP to market-ready SaaS platform

Combat Engineer

2007-10-01 — 2011-09-30

HM Forces

Served as Combat Engineer with frontline deployment to Afghanistan, specializing in route clearance and IED detection operations. Gained comprehensive training in mechanical and electrical engineering while developing exceptional problem-solving skills under pressure. Experience included operating complex military equipment and working effectively in high-stakes team environments.

- Served frontline tour in Afghanistan as Royal Engineer
- Specialized in IED detection and route clearance operations
- Trained in mechanical and electrical engineering fundamentals
- Operated and maintained Challenger 2 main battle tanks

EDUCATION

Mechanical Engineering & Technology

HM Forces Apprenticeship Scheme

2007-01-01 — 2011-12-31

SKILLS

Developer Advocacy | Backend Engineering | Frontend Engineering | Leadership & Communication | Software Architecture | DevOps & Infrastructure | Quality & Testing

PUBLICATIONS

Building your first MCP server with Laravel

2025-10-09

Sevalla Blog

Comprehensive guide to the Model Context Protocol (MCP), demonstrating how to build AI-native Laravel applications that can be confidently used by AI assistants like Claude.

Building an API Starter Kit for Laravel

2024-12

PHP Architect

Deep-dive into Laravel application architecture patterns, featuring real-world case studies and performance optimization techniques.

How Steve Writes Laravel Code

2024-09

PHP Architect

Comprehensive exploration of clean code patterns and AI integration in modern PHP applications.

API Essentials: A Developer's Guide to Authentication, Validation, and DTOs

2024-02

PHP Architect

In-depth exploration of essential API development concepts in Laravel, including authentication strategies and Data Transfer Objects (DTOs).

Hooked On Functionality: The Whimsical World Of Webhooks In PHP

2024-01

PHP Architect

Practical implementation guide for webhook systems in PHP, covering security best practices and event-driven architecture.

AWARDS

PHP Community Recognition

PHP FIG (2024-02-01)

Outstanding Technical Writing

php[architect] Magazine (2023-12-01)

CERTIFICATES

Laravel Certified Developer

Certification for Laravel (2025-09-01)